On the other hand, maybe it wasn't the mere closeness of living things that I liked. Maybe it was the mind-boggling number. In a matter of hours I'd gone from a place of aridity, sterility, death, to a wetland of teeming fertility. Maybe that was what I yearned for most of all—life.

Maybe that was the real miracle I found in the Okavango in April 1999.

I don't think I blinked once that whole week. I don't think I stopped grinning, even while asleep. Had I been transported back to the Jurassic period, I couldn't have been more awed—and it wasn't just *T. rex*es that had me captivated. I loved the littlest creatures too. And the birds. Thanks to Adi, clearly the savviest guide in our group, I began to recognize hooded vultures, cattle egrets, southern carmine bee-eaters, African fish eagles, in flight. Even the bugs were compelling. Adi taught me to really *see* them. Look down, he said, note the different species of beetle, admire the beauty of larvae. Also, appreciate the baroque architecture of termite mounds—the tallest structures built by any animal besides humans.

So much to know, Harry. To appreciate.

Right, Adi.

Whenever I went with him on a wander, whenever we'd come upon a fresh carcass crawling with maggots or wild dogs, whenever we'd stumble on a mountain of elephant dung sprouting mushrooms that looked like the Artful Dodger's top hat, Adi never cringed. *Circle of life, Harry.*

Of all the animals in our midst, Adi said, the most majestic was the water. The Okavango was just another living thing. He'd walked its entire length as a boy, with his father, carrying nothing but bedrolls. He knew the Okavango inside and out, and felt for it something like romantic love. Its surface was a poreless cheek, which he often lightly stroked.

But he also felt for the river a kind of sober awe. Respect. Its innards were death, he said. Hungry crocs, ill-tempered hippos, they were all down there, in the dark, waiting for you to slip up. Hippos killed five hundred people a year; Adi drummed it into my head over and over, and all these years later I can still hear him: *Never go into the dark water, Harry.*

One night around the fire, all the guides and trackers discussed the river, shouting stories about riding it, swimming it, boating it, fearing it, everyone talking over each other. I heard it all that night, the mysticism of the river, the sacredness of the river, the weirdness of the river.

Speaking of weirdness…The smell of marijuana wafted on the air.

The stories grew louder, sillier.